



Civic Meeting Report

2025 Budget Hearings September 4th Segment #2

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dFBVy3iUUEI
Publication Date	2024-09-05T00:31:34Z
Target Category	delaware_county

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Delaware County Municipal Meeting Report

Meeting Type: Municipal Budget Work Session

Record Generated: October 24, 2023 *(Implicitly derived from context)*

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** The meeting was called to order by the presiding board officer to review agency and department budget requests for the upcoming fiscal cycle.
- **Attendance:** Multiple board members (Council/Commissioners), department heads, and elected officials were present, including references to Councilman Hughes and various departmental leaders.

3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** None recorded in this segment.
- **Approval of Minutes:** None recorded in this segment.

4. Substantive Business & Board Action

- **00:00:11 Emergency Medical Services (EMS) Department Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** EMS Department Director.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The board reviewed EMS line-item expenses, salary structures (bringing EMTs and paramedics closer to midpoint salary study projections), staffing turnovers, overtime costs driven by minimum manning requirements, and line adjustments. The director noted a new law, House Bill 1385, set to take effect allowing higher private insurance reimbursements (400% over Medicare rates), which could significantly increase revenue. Discussions also covered capital costs, including replacing an ambulance involved in a recent crash, and a review of the county employee handbook regarding educational incentive pay.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Salary adjustments were made on the floor (reducing the director's salary request and modifying an Advanced EMT line item), reducing the total requested amount to \$2,784,256. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **03:47:00 Communications / 911 Dispatch Budgets Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Communications / Dispatch Director.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed dispatch salary adjustments, upcoming auto-dispatch software maintenance costs, staffing shortages (noting an eight-position deficit per a Ritter staffing study), office supply cost increases (including water filtration/Culligan services), chair lease costs, uniform lines, and the health of the Statewide 911 fund. The board discussed long-term capital needs for phone and radio systems, and the potential necessity of raising local income tax (LIT) rates to adequately fund public safety operations.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Discussed as part of ongoing budget work sessions; no final roll call vote taken. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **01:06:57 Sheriff's Department & Jail Budgets Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Sheriff.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The Sheriff presented budget requests for sworn Merit deputies, corrections officers, and jail operations. Key discussions focused on pension obligations, the critical state of vehicle maintenance and replacement fleets due to high mileage and transport demands (averaging 10,000 miles a month), educational incentive pay, and severe recruitment/retention challenges driven by higher-paying neighboring counties. The Sheriff highlighted that the jail generates substantial unbudgeted revenue (\$142,000 in August alone) by housing state and federal inmates, arguing that these funds should support staff salary increases.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Budget figures reviewed; line-item corrections made for FICA and PERF. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **02:39:02 Prosecutor's Office Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Prosecutor.

- **Deliberation Summary:** The Prosecutor presented requests for Title IV-D Child Support, the High-Tech Crime Unit (100% state-funded), and County General/LIT Public Safety allocations. He advocated strongly for adopting a new attorney pay matrix developed in a statewide study to resolve severe staffing shortages and retain experienced deputy prosecutors. The discussion touched on the disparity between public defender/public-part-time pay and full-time deputy prosecutor compensation, as well as the use of Pre-Trial Diversion user fees.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed alongside companion state/grant funds. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **03:10:30 Health Insurance Fund Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Bill Sylvester (Apex Benefits).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The benefits consultant reviewed the county's self-funded health insurance fund (Fund 4701), noting that it operates as a nonreverting fund but has been significantly depleted over prior years. Sylvester recommended building back the operational cushion to cover maximum claims liability and projected a 10% increase in health costs for the upcoming year. The board debated how department health insurance line items interact with the central fund.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Informational presentation; no formal vote taken.
- **03:46:06 Community Corrections & Court Services Budgets Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Jane (Court Services / Community Corrections Director).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed project income balances, Department of Correction (DOC) grant allocations, and user fee fund restructurings (separating drug court, veterans court, and community corrections funds). The director confirmed healthy grant execution rates and discussed monitoring contract costs.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed and accepted into the budget record by Voice Vote.
- **03:58:04 Commissioners' Budget & Building Maintenance Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Commissioners / Maintenance Staff.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Covered institutional care costs, utility increases, the copier lease program, and a request for a new building maintenance floater position to address extensive accumulated compensatory time (overtime balances owed to existing maintenance staff). The Veterans Service Officer also presented staffing and operational funding requests.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed; adjustments noted for further consideration. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **04:39:20 Airport Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Tim (Airport Director).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Presented a streamlined budget showing a net decrease from the prior year. Highlighted upcoming grant-funded capital projects, specifically a 100% FAA-funded wildlife security fence project with a local match phase.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.

- **04:41:35 Highway & Engineering Department Budgets Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Highway Engineer / Department Representatives.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed Cumulative Bridge funds, local road and street allocations, equipment replacement leases (including dump truck lease payments), bridge inspection mandates, and a controversial proposal for a new county engineer position. The engineer detailed material costs for paving and chip-and-seal programs.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **03:35:26 Health Department Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Jamie (Health Department Administrator).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Presented local health maintenance funds and the Health First Indiana (HFI) state funding allocation (Fund 1161). The administrator outlined program expansions, local partnerships (including Recovery Cafe, YMCA, tobacco-free coalitions, and AED distributions to volunteer fire departments), vital records staffing additions, and strategies for maximizing interest income on state grant balances. He cautioned against cutting local baseline matching funds (Fund 1159).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed and accepted into the record by Voice Vote.
- **06:07:35 Public Defender's Office Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Sam Beasley (Chief Public Defender).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Presented staffing levels, attorney compensation adjustments aligned with the salary study, investigator hires, and administrative assistant reclassifications. The office discussed escalating costs for attorney fees and transcript expenses due to a heavy upcoming trial backlog (including multiple murder trials).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.
- **06:37:26 Clerk's Office & Election Budgets Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Clerk.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed non-election year budget reductions for the election division, computer replacement schedules for office hardware, professional services/bank fees, and record perpetuation funds. The Clerk outlined an upcoming major voter registration roll-cleaning project and a file organization initiative for historical records.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed. Approved by Voice Vote.

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- *No open public comment or citizen forum period was held during this administrative budget work session.*
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6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:** The board scheduled reconvening for the following morning at 08:30 to continue budget deliberations.
 - **Adjournment:** The meeting was recessed at the conclusion of the evening session by the presiding officer.
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